and Rajput. When Abu'l Fazl would begin work on the *Ain-i Akbari*, he would, for the first time in the history of the Mughal Empire, declare that the Mughal women were pardeh-giyan, the veiled ones. The women would be further hidden behind grandiose titles which made them indistinguishable, Hindu, Persian or Turk. Hamida Banu would be transformed into Maryam Makani* and Harkha Bai into Maryam uz Zamani† and when they were mentioned at all in the records, they were now always resolutely 'chaste'.

There were other ways in which the Rajput women brought their culture into the Mughal world. As their life in seclusion was physically constrained, Rajput women often turned to religion both as emotional sustenance and as a source of entertainment. There were almost daily functions, distracting with their rituals and their effervescent colour. There was Basant Panchami, Holi, Rakhi, Dussehra, Diwali, Teej, and Janmashtami, breaking the monotony of their years and colouring the background of their lives. They had access to the royal priests as well as female Brahmins so they could conduct these rituals with panache and fervour. 'From early youth, in compliment to his wives, the daughters of the Rajahs of Hind,' railed Badauni bitterly, 'he had within the female apartments continued to offer the hom, which is a ceremony derived from sun-worship.' To Badauni it was clear that this nefarious influence on Akbar was at least partly due to these Rajput women. He grumbled gloomily about the 'jewelled strings tied on his wrists, by Brahmans, by way of a blessing' and the abhorrent 'current custom also to wear the rakhi on the wrist, which means an amulet formed out of twisted linen rags'. Still later Badauni would note that even Akbar's sartorial choices were influenced by Hindus. 'Certain pandering pimps,' he clarified, 'brought forward proofs in favour of shaving the beard.' The Rajput wives 'had influenced his mind against…association with people who wore beards. And in order to gain their love and goodwill, and that of their castes, he abstained entirely from anything which was a natural abhorrence to these people, and looked on it as a mark of special devotion to himself if men shaved off their beards—so that this became a common practice.' And indeed Akbar never did keep a beard, only a small moustache, and he grew his hair long out of deference to the habits of his Hindu subjects.

If religious festivals were an important part of the lives of Akbar's Rajput wives, then so were fasts, which were essential to elite Rajput